

On the bright side, they were able to spend less because they were forced to customize, thinking critically about every expense and whether it worked for them as two grooms. Statistically, according to a 2016 study by LOGO and the Knot, seven out of ten gay couples are more likely to foot the bill for their weddings without any family support compared to one in ten straight couples. (Sadly, too many of my LGBTQ friends have had parents who opposed their relationships and did not even attend their weddings.)

That same study revealed that gay male couples are actually now on average spending more on weddings (and also honeymoons) than they ever have before. Queer men are spending on average \$33,000 for their weddings while lesbian and bi women are spending \$25,000, but both numbers have grown massively in percentage since marriage equality passed in the United States in 2015. This may be because the joining of two average male incomes allows bigger wedding budgets. Queer male couples' wedding spending has risen 85 percent, and for queer women couples, that number grew 56 percent. In the same time frame from, 2015 to 2017, spending went up 1 percent for cisgender straight men and 15 percent for cisgender straight women.

As a bisexual woman, I have a soft spot for queer couples who want big weddings. We want the happy memories straight people have had forever. "These people have been thinking they'll never have an opportunity to walk down that aisle or have that first dance and now they can," said Shanie McCowen, a same-sex wedding planner in destination hubs Niagara Falls and South Florida.

McCowen, who has worked on more than 200 LGBTQ weddings, told me about a gay male couple she planned a wedding for that had only four guests. They spent \$20,000 and had a private chef, rented a mansion, bought expensive gifts for their guests, booked a private driver for the whole weekend, took a helicopter ride over Niagara Falls, and spent over \$2,000 for the flowers for just one room of the mansion. (Let us have this, okay? John Schneider of the *Queer Money* podcast points out that "in 28 states, you can still be fired for being LGBTQ. So while you can get married to your partner in any state in the country, if you put your wedding photo on your desk, you could get fired.") If a couple wants to cut corners, though, McCowen recommends eliminating